MOREH NEVUCHIM

Is God Nearer in Heaven? The Rambam on Drawing Near & Filling

Given Tuesday 6 October 2026 · Moreh Nevuchim I:18-19

Sefer: Moreh Nevuchim (Rambam), Chelek Aleph — Rabbi Chaim Makbili's Hebrew edition / Sefaria

Chapters: I:18 — the three terms for drawing near: **קרב, נגע, נגש**; I:19 — the term **מלא** (to fill)

Topic: Spatial versus intellectual nearness; why God can be neither near nor far in space; the verses we say every day (קרוב ה' לכל קוראיו) and what they really mean; God "touching"; why the Rambam leaves out **דבק**; the three meanings of **מלא**; **מלא כל הארץ כבודו**; and why our prayers are better received at the Kotel

Schedule note: First Moreh shiur after Tishrei. The Tuesday Moreh shiur now continues **every week through the winter**, until further notice. **No Thursday shiur this week**; the other shiurim resume next week. Chapter 20 was not reached and opens next week.

Recap — Chapter 17

Last time we reviewed Chapters 1–16 and then learned **Chapter 17**, where the Rambam continued the theme of **צור** (the source of all existence). He taught that profound theological and scientific matters must sometimes be expressed through **metaphor**, because revealing them openly can be harmful. Using Aristotle, he set out the three building blocks of all existence: **חומר, צורה and העדר** (matter, form and privation). By the nature of matter, when one deficiency is filled another emerges.

He applied this to people: we are naturally driven to seek more, materially, intellectually and spiritually. So the Rambam must be careful not to reveal too much at once and "drown" us.

Chapter 17 was a digression, prompted by צור in Chapter 16. **In Chapter 18 the Rambam returns to explaining verbs**, and continues doing so for the next few chapters.

Chapter 18 — קרב, נגע, נגש

The Three Verbs

Verb	Plain meaning
קרב	To draw near
נגע	To touch
נגש	To approach, draw close

שלושת המונחים הללו, כלומר קריבה, נגיעה, נגישה, נאמרים לעתים במשמעות של מגע וקירבה במקום, ולעתים במשמעות של התקשרות הידיעה בדבר הנודע, והרי זה כאילו דומה לקירבת גוף אל גוף.

All three verbs carry **two meanings**:

1. **Spatial** — physical nearness or touch.
2. **Intellectual** — the mind coming close to, or "touching", something it knows. It is *like* physical nearness, but nothing moves in space.

What Is the Difference Between Them? (Abarbanel)

Abarbanel ranks them by degree of closeness:

Degree	Verb	Meaning
1	**קרב**	I was far, and I draw near
2	**נגש**	I draw even nearer
3	**נגע**	I touch: the closest of all

Then why does the Rambam list them as קרב, נגע, נגש, rather than in ascending order? Abarbanel's answer: **קרב and נגע are used of anything**, human or not, animate or inanimate. **נגש is used only of a person approaching.** Because they are different kinds of verb, the Rambam groups them this way. *(Keep this in mind; it matters later in the chapter.)*

Meaning 1 — Spatial Nearness

הנה המשמעות הראשונה של קריבה, שהיא קריבה במקום:

קרב:

ויהי כאשר קרב אל המחנה וירא את העגל ומחלת (Ki Tisa)

Moshe has been away for forty days; he comes near the camp, sees them dancing and breaks the luchot.

ופרעה הקריב

Pharaoh, after pursuing Bnei Yisrael for three days, draws near.

נגע — מגע גוף בגוף, body touching body:

ותגע לרגליו

The mysterious episode at the start of Shemot: Moshe is in some danger, Tzipporah circumcises their son and makes the blood touch his feet. Whether these are Moshe's feet or the child's is a **machloket Rishonim**; either way, a physical touch.

ויגע על פי (Yeshayahu)

This is a prophecy, and **the Rambam holds that all prophecy comes in a vision or dream**, as we will learn. But *within* the vision there was a physical touch. It did not materially happen, but in the vision it is spatial touching.

נגש — התקדמות אדם אחד אל אדם אחר, one person approaching another:

ויגש אליו יהודה ויאמר בי אדני

The opening of Vayigash: Yehudah comes very close to Yosef to plead for Binyamin.

Meaning 2 — Intellectual Nearness

והמשמעות השנייה של שלושת המונחים הללו היא קישור בידיעה, מגע של השגה, לא מגע של מקום.

Contact of apprehension, not contact of place. The Rambam begins this time with **נגע** (the Rabbi isn't sure why):

נגע:

כי נגע אל השמים משפטה (Yirmiyahu, of Bavel)

Bavel has not touched the sky. It means their conduct has **come right up before Me**; it must be dealt with.

קרב:

והדבר אשר יקשה מכם תקריבון אלי ושמעתיו (Devarim, Moshe retelling the court system Yitro advised)

The hardest cases come to Moshe. This does not mean physically carrying the case papers to him. It means **כאילו נאמר: תודיעוני**, *inform me*: bring it to my attention so I can consider it. **הרי ששימש בהוראת ידיעת דבר מדבר.**

נגש:

ויגש אברהם ויאמר (Vayera, Sedom)

Avraham did not physically move while speaking to Hashem. **היה זה בהתגלות ובמראית הנבואה** — he drew near **prophetically**, developing himself intellectually to speak with Hashem. And at the end of the episode, **ואברהם שב למקומו**: the prophecy ended. (We will see this verse again.)

יען כי נגש העם הזה בפיו ובשפתיו כבדוני, ולבו רחק ממני (Yeshayahu)

Yeshayahu's famous complaint: the people draw near with their **lips**, but their **hearts** are far. When we pray, we do not come physically near to Hashem; we try to draw near intellectually. These people do it only with their lips.

With God — Only the Second Meaning

אם כן, כל לשון קריבה או נגישה שתמצא בספרי הנבואה בין השם יתברך לבין הנבראים — כולם מהמשמעות האחרונה הזו.

כי השם יתברך אינו גוף. *(As we will prove philosophically later.)*

ולכן הוא יתעלה אינו נוגע בדבר ולא מתקרב לדבר, ושום דבר אינו מתקרב אליו ואינו נוגע בו יתעלה. כי כשאין גשמיות אין מקום, ומתבטלים כל קירבה או מגע או ריחוק או קשירות או היפרדות או השקה או סמיכות.

Where there is no body there is no place. So every word for nearness, contact, distance, conjunction, separation, touching or proximity **means nothing in space** when used between God and His creatures. Whenever these verbs describe us and Hashem, they mean **intellectual** positioning: coming closer, or moving further away, in understanding.

Why the Rambam leaves out נגיעה here (Abarbanel)

Notice his wording: **כל לשון קריבה או נגישה**. He omits **נגיעה**, though he uses it elsewhere in the chapter.

Abarbanel: because **you will never find נגע used of a human being towards Hashem.** (You may find it the other way round; see below.) נגע is the closest degree, and the Torah says **כי לא תוכל לראות את פני**: there is a limit to how close we can come to Hashem, even intellectually. Even in prophecy there is no complete union. So the word for full contact is never used of man reaching God.

This is why, for example, Yaakov's ladder says:

והנה סלם מצב ארצה וראשו מגיע השמימה

Its top reaches **heaven**, not God. As we have seen twice already, the ladder is a metaphor for **prophetic ascent**: the climb reaches heaven intellectually, but never "touches" Hashem.

Verses You May Have Been Misreading All Your Life

ואל יסבור שמה שנאמר: קרוב ה' לכל קוראיו... או: קרבת אלהים יחפצון... או: ואני קרבת אלהים לי טוב — יגרום לך ספק או בלבול. כי כל אלה קרבת ידיעה, כלומר השגה של ידע, לא קרבת מקום.

1. קרוב ה' לכל קוראיו, לכל אשר יקראהו באמת

We say this in **Ashrei three times a day**. Does it mean Hashem moves closer to us? Of course not.

This is the theme of **השגחה** (providence), which the Rambam develops in Chapter 21, throughout Section 2 and especially later in the book. The degree of Hashem's providence over a person **matches how far that person places themselves under it**.

The Rabbi's analogy: a beam of light. Think of the opening of the *Mr Bean* films, where he falls into a beam of light. **When you step into the beam, you are in the light.** Seek Hashem in truth and you put yourself under the beam: you feel the השגחה. No spatial movement is involved.

So tomorrow morning in Ashrei: קרוב ה' means that **if we put ourselves in Hashem's light, we come under His השגחה.**

2. קרבת אלהים יחפצון

Read the verse in context (Yeshayahu 58):

ואותי יום יום ידרשון, ודעת דרכי יחפצון, כגוי אשר צדקה עשה ומשפט אלהיו לא עזב, ישאלוני משפטי צדק, קרבת אלהים יחפצון.

The whole verse is intellectual: **seek Me out, desire to know My ways, inquire into My just laws** — and then, **they will desire nearness to God**. The nearness comes from understanding His Torah, His world and His universe.

3. ואני קרבת אלהים לי טוב

The full verse (Tehillim 73):

ואני קרבת אלהים לי טוב, שתי באדנ-י ה' מחסי, לספר כל מלאכותיך.

What does David mean by nearness to God? The rest of the verse says: **making Hashem my refuge** (bitachon) and **recounting all His works** (the world He has made).

Similar verses

כי מי גוי גדול אשר לו אלהים קרבים אליו, כה' אלהינו בכל קראנו אליו (Va'etchanan)

We are fortunate to have Hashem "near" us. The end of the verse explains: **whenever we call to Him.** It means we can have a **relationship** with Him, not that He comes physically closer.

קרב אתה ושמע את כל אשר יאמר ה' אלהינו (said to Moshe before the Aseret HaDibrot)

Draw near = **prepare yourself intellectually** to receive.

ונגש משה לבדו אל ה', והם לא יגשו (Yitro / Mishpatim)

Moshe alone may apprehend Hashem **as far as a human being can**; the elders and the people cannot.

The Rambam's Leeway — Rav Saadia's Approach

As in **Chapter 5** (the burning bush), the Rambam offers a fallback for those who find this hard:

אלא אם תרצה להבין שמה שאמר על משה "ונגש" — שהכוונה היא שהוא יתקרב אל המקום בהר אשר נברא בו האור, כלומר כבוד ה' — יכול אתה.

If you prefer to say that Moshe approached **the place on the mountain where a created light appeared** — a physical manifestation called **כבוד ה'**, created by God but not God Himself — **you may.** This is how **Rav Saadia Gaon** often reads such verses. **It is not heresy, but it is not correct.**

אבל החזק בעיקר: שאין הבדל בין אם האדם במרכז הארץ או על גבי הגלגל התשיעי, לו היה אפשר — אינו רחוק מן השם פה ולא קרוב שם. אלא הקרבה אליו יתעלה היא בהשגתו, והריחוק ממנו הוא באי ידיעתו.

Hold on to the main principle. Whether you are at the centre of the earth or on the **ninth sphere** (the highest heaven in their cosmology), even if that were possible, **you are no nearer**

to Hashem there and no further from Him here. Nearness to Him **is knowing Him**; distance from Him **is not knowing Him**.

ומן הפינה הזאת יש הבדלים גדולים מאוד בין בני אדם בין הקרוב והרחוק.

In *that* sense, people differ enormously in how near or far they are. The Rambam will explain the levels of apprehension later.

Rav Kappach brings a verse that captures it perfectly:

אם אסק שמים שם אתה, ואציעה שאול הנך (Tehillim 139)

Whether I climb to the heavens or lie down in the grave, You are there. We are no nearer and no further either way.

When God "Touches"

So far: humans drawing near to Hashem. What about verses where **Hashem touches something**?

ה' הט שמיך ותרד, גע בהרים ויעשנו (Tehillim 144)

Hashem, bend Your heavens and come down; **touch the mountains and they will smoke.**

הכוונה היא: הבא ציווייך עליהם. as it says of Iyov: וגע אל עצמו — Bring Your decree upon them, **כלומר שלח בו מכותיך.**

Iyov first: Iyov's family and possessions have been struck, and the Satan says, *but You have not touched his own flesh*: **וגע אל עצמו**. Meaning: **bring Your decree, Your affliction, upon Iyov himself.** So too **גע בהרים ויעשנו**: Hashem need only decide, need only *will* it, and the mountains smoke. **"Touching", for God, is the coming of His decree upon something.** No physical contact.

An aside on the Satan: do not imagine a creature called the Satan. **There is no Satan as a being in the Rambam's philosophy**, and it makes no sense. Later in the Moreh the Rambam explains that **שטן derives from שטה/סטה**, to turn aside: a complete distancing, a turning away from Hashem.

Apply It Elsewhere — הבן זאת

וכן יש לבחון בכל מקום כפי עניינו את הנגיעה וכל מה שנגזר ממנה: לעתים הכוונה מגע גוף בגוף, ולעתים התקשרות ידיעה והשגת דבר מה, כאילו מי שמשיג דבר שהיה רחוק ממנו — התקרב אליו. הבן זאת.

Judge each occurrence by its context. **Why add "הבן זאת", understand this?** The **Efodi** suggests the Rambam is pointing to two verses he wants us to read this way:

1. Har Sinai (Yitro):

השמרו לכם עלות בהר ונגע בקצהו; כל הנגע בהר מות יומת

The simple reading is physical. But it can also mean: **whoever "touches" the mountain** — whoever tries to go too high in apprehending Hashem at the revelation — **will die**, will be unable to bear it.

2. The Etz HaDaat (this week's parashah, Bereishit):

ומפרי העץ אשר בתוך הגן אמר אלהים לא תאכלו ממנו ולא תגעו בו פן תמתון

The simple story: don't touch it, or you will die. Or: **don't come too close intellectually**; don't try to grasp too much knowledge too fast. Do that and you will go mad.

The four who entered the Pardes (to be discussed in detail later in the Moreh): only **Rabbi Akiva** came out whole. The others went too far intellectually: **one died, one went mad, and one lost his faith.** That is "touching and dying": coming too close, intellectually.

The Fourth Verb — Why Doesn't the Rambam Mention דבק?

The Rabbi's question: can you think of a **fourth** verb that means both physical and intellectual closeness and is used of Hashem in the Torah — one you would have expected the Rambam to bring? It's in Sefer Devarim, and we say it many times on Yom Kippur:

ואתם הדבקים בה' אלהיכם, חיים כלכם היום

And in **this week's parashah**:

ודבק באשתו והיו לבשר אחד

Hashem creates Chava and says the man **shall cleave** to his wife and they become one flesh, through intimacy or through the child they create together. **At least** a physical attachment. And **ואתם הדבקים בה'** says you are *stuck* to Hashem, glued to Him. If anything, **דבק is the strongest word of all** (in modern Hebrew it's what glue does). **So why does the Rambam never discuss it?**

Suggestions from the class: it is purely intellectual, so it couldn't be used of a human and Hashem; or it refers to the heart, which is separate from the intellect. **The Rabbi:** but then how would you explain *you are stuck to Hashem*?

The answer: the Rambam expects you to know the Gemara before you learn the Moreh. He deals with what is *not* already explicit in the Talmud, and **the Gemara already asks this question** (Ketubot 111b):

"ואתם הדבקים בה' אלהיכם" — וכי אפשר לדבוקי בשכינה? והלא כבר נאמר: כי ה' אלהיך אש אכלה הוא! אלא: כל המשיא בתו לתלמיד חכם, והעושה פרקמטיא לתלמידי חכמים, והמהנה תלמידי חכמים מנכסיו — מעלה עליו הכתוב כאילו מדבק בשכינה.

כיוצא בדבר אתה אומר: "לאהבה את ה' אלהיך... ולדבקה בו" — וכי אפשר לאדם לידבק בשכינה? אלא... (the same answer)

How can one cleave to the Shechinah, which is a consuming fire? Rather: marry your daughter to a talmid chacham, do business with talmidei chachamim (help them earn a living), let them benefit from your property — **and Scripture counts it as if you cleaved to the Shechinah.**

But why didn't the Gemara simply say it means intellectual cleaving? Because the verse says **חיים כלכם היום — *all* of you.** Not every Jew experiences that intimate intellectual closeness to Hashem. So the Gemara could not read it as intellectual positioning. It had to refer it to **the manifestation of Hashem in this world** — the closest thing we have: **the chachamim**, and before them the **kohanim** (hence the gifts to the kohanim), who represent Hashem in the world as far as anything can. **All of you cleave to Hashem through your attachment to Moshe and the chachamim across the generations.**

This matches what the Rambam taught in this chapter about כבוד ה': a created manifestation that one can approach. That is why דבק needed no chapter of its own.

Chapter 18 — Summary

The three verbs **קרב, נגש and נגע** can mean physically approaching, coming near or touching, or **intellectual and spiritual closeness**. Whenever they are used of Hashem, only the second meaning applies: closeness through **prophecy, prayer, trust (bitachon), seeking refuge in Him** — never physical proximity, because God has no body and therefore no place. **נגע, full contact, is never used of a human reaching Hashem**, because no one can see His face. The everyday verses — **קרוב ה' לכל קוראיו**, **קרבת אלהים יחפצון**, **ואני קרבת אלהים לי טוב** — all speak of nearness through knowledge, providence and trust. If that is too hard, you may read them with Rav Saadia as approaching a **created** glory, **כבוד ה'**; that is acceptable but not the true meaning. **When Hashem "touches" something, it means His decree coming upon it.** And **דבק** is absent because the Gemara already explained it: cleaving to the chachamim, Hashem's representatives in the world.

Chapter 19 — מלא (To Fill)

Why Here?

Makbili suggests the link is **Yeshayahu 6**, the vision of Hashem on a high and exalted throne, **ושוליו מלאים את ההיכל** — His train **filled** the Heichal. In that same chapter: **ויגע על פי** — one of the **seraphim** touched Yeshayahu's mouth (a seraph, *not* Hashem, just as Abarbanel said). Chapter 18 dealt with נגיעה in a spiritual context, so Chapter 19 turns to **מלא** from the same vision, and **Chapter 20** will take **רם ונשא**, also from that vision.

The Three Meanings of מלא

מלא — מונח רב משמעי.

1. One body filling another

דוברי השפה משתמשים בו לגבי גוף הנמצא בתוך גוף וממלא אותו.

Rivkah fills her pitcher with water: two physical things, one — (Chayei Sarah) **ותמלא כדה ותעל** — filling the other.

מלא העמר לאחד — an omer-full of manna for each person.

A note on quotation: Makbili points out that **this exact phrase is not in the Torah**. The verses read **מלא העמר ממנו** and, a few verses later, **שני העמר לאחד**. The Rambam has merged them **from memory**. **Rav Kappach** notes many times that the Rambam quoted pesukim from memory — he did not always have a Chumash in front of him — so a word or letter is sometimes slightly different. We'll see another example next chapter (**מתוך העפר** where the verse says **מן העפר**).

2. The completion of a period of time

ומשתמשים בו במובן של תום פרק זמן מסוים.

וימלאו ימיה ללדת, והנה תומם בבטנה — Rivkah's days were "full": her nine months were complete.

וימלאו לו ארבעים יום, כי כן ימלאו ימי החנטים — the forty days of Yaakov's embalming were completed.

Nothing physical fills anything. Completing a span of time is **filling it** — in time rather than in space.

3. Perfection — attaining the height of excellence

ומשתמשים בו במובן של שלמות במעלה והגעת תכליתה.

ונפתלי שבע רצון ומלא ברכת ה' — Naftali is **full** of (read a few days ago on Simchat Torah) Hashem's blessing: not space, not time, but **excellence**.

מלא אתם חכמת לב לעשות כל מלאכת חרש וחשב — Hashem filled Betzalel, Ohaliav and the other artisans with wisdom.

וימלא את החכמה ואת התבונה ואת הדעת — Chiram, the craftsman of the Beit HaMikdash: intellectual filling, and a perfection.

Meaning	Sense	Example
1	Body within body (space)	ותמלא כדה
2	Completion of time	וימלאו ימיה ללדת
3	**Perfection and excellence**	ומלא ברכת ה'

מלא כל הארץ כבודו

ובמשמעות הזה נאמר: מלא כל הארץ כבודו — פירוש הדברים: כל הארץ מעידה על שלמותו, כלומר מורה עליה.

קדוש קדוש קדוש ה' צבאות, מלא כל הארץ כבודו — said several times a day. *(We have not yet defined **כבוד**; for now take it simply as His glory.)* It does **not** mean filling space (meaning 1), nor completing time (meaning 2). It means **meaning 3**: **the whole earth testifies to His perfection.**

This is why the Rambam writes in so many places that studying the universe brings a person to understand Hashem. The universe is not perfect in every part — physical things come into being and decay — but **as a whole**, its harmony, its symphony and its rhythm **display Hashem's wisdom and perfection.** A person who is "full" has all the qualities, and the universe is full of His.

וכבוד ה' מלא את המשכן

כיוצא בזה נאמר: וכבוד ה' מלא את המשכן (Pekudei)

Once the Mishkan and all its vessels were complete, the glory of Hashem "filled" it. Not physically (He has no body), not in time (no time is involved), but **meaning 3**: through the building of the Mishkan, Hashem's glory was made **whole and manifest**. Seeing the Mishkan

functioning, the kohanim, the avodah, one could **experience the divine there more than anywhere else**.

Why Are Our Prayers Better Received at the Kotel?

This means there is no intrinsic holiness to a place.

The Rabbi's question: why is the Kotel a place where our prayers are more readily accepted? *"Because the Beit HaMikdash was there, so Hashem is closer there"?* Based on Chapters 18 and 19 we should all be shouting: **that cannot be.** Hashem is everywhere; on the ninth sphere or anywhere on earth, He is equally near.

The real reason: the Kotel is a place where **כבוד ה' was manifest**: **וכבוד ה' מלא את המשכן**. When the Mishkan and the Beit HaMikdash stood, one saw Hashem's excellence there — the beauty, the order, the people, the avodah. **Because of that history, one experiences the divine more there.** Being there, a person rises spiritually and comes closer to Hashem **intellectually**, comes more fully under His **השגחה** — and **then** his prayers are naturally more accepted.

It is wrong to think: *"I'm at the Kotel now, so the same prayers I say everywhere automatically count for more."* **Your prayers are the same prayers.** They are more accepted **only if you tune in**: *because I am at the Kotel I experience Hashem more, I come under His השגחה more* — and everything else flows from that.

The Rambam's Conclusion — and His Leeway Again

וכל לשון מלאה שתמצא מיוחסת להשם יתברך — היא מהמשמעות הזאת, לא שיש גוף שממלא מקום.

Whenever מלא is used of Hashem, it means **perfection and excellence** — never, God forbid, a body filling a space.

אלא אם תרצה להבין את כבוד ה' כאור הנברא, המכונה כבוד, והוא שמלא את המשכן — אין נזק בכך.

Again the Rambam allows the fallback: if you are not ready, read **כבוד ה'** as a **created light** — a physical manifestation, not Hashem Himself — that filled the Mishkan, as **Rav Saadia Gaon** does. **No harm; not heresy.** But it is not the true meaning, and you should be working towards understanding that **Hashem's excellence and perfection** filled the Mishkan. **What is unacceptable — "off the charts" — is thinking Hashem Himself filled the Mishkan.**

And for us: a person becomes "full" by contemplating Hashem through the universe, its structure, and the structure of things like the Mishkan.

Chapter 19 — Summary

מלא has three meanings: **(1)** filling something in space (water in a pitcher), **(2)** completing a period of time, and **(3) perfection and excellence**. Used of Hashem, it never means that He physically occupies space. **מלא כל הארץ כבודו** means the universe displays His wisdom and perfection, so that through it we come to know Him; **וכבוד ה' מלא את המשכן** means the Mishkan was a powerful setting in which the divine could be experienced and recognised — which is also why prayer is better received at the Kotel, **not because Hashem is more there, but because we can be more there.** Rav Saadia's reading (a created glory filling the Mishkan) is permitted but is not the main meaning.

Coming Up

- **Next week: Chapter 20** — the two terms **רם** and **נשא** (exalted, lifted up). A short chapter, about 15 minutes.
- Then a start on **Chapter 21** — **עבר** (to pass: **ויעבר ה' על פניו**). **A huge and fundamental chapter**, at least two shiurim, maybe more.
- There is a small chance the Rabbi cannot give next week's shiur; assume it is on at the normal time unless told otherwise.
- **No Thursday shiur this week**; all shiurim resume next week.

B'Ezrat Hashem

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